STATE SCAN

TAMIL NADU: STALIN GETS A SLOGAN *PG 20*

UP: THE GORAKHPUR MODEL *PG 24*



MV *WAN HAI 503*

FLAG: Singapore

ROUTE: Colombo to Mumbai

MISHAP: Explosion/ fire off Azhikkal (Kannur) coast

DATE: June 9

CARGO: 650 containers with flammable/ hazardous materials, like nitrocellulose, alcohol, lithium batteries, besides 2,000 tonnes of marine oil and 240 tonnes of diesel



▶ KERALA

A SEA OF TROUBLES

As two shipwrecks foul its coastal waters, Kerala finds itself staring at a deepening maritime emergency that threatens its fragile marine ecology and millions of livelihoods

By **Jeemon Jacob**

In the span of just two weeks, Kerala's 600-kilometre shoreline—a ribbon of emerald backwaters and bustling fishing hamlets—has been rattled by two catastrophic maritime mishaps involving cargo ships, sending shockwaves through its coastal communities and unfurling environmental red flags.

The first blow came on May 25, when the Liberian-flagged MSC *Elsa 3*, a hulking vessel carrying 643 containers, succumbed to a suspected mechanical failure and sank 14.6 nautical miles off the Thottappally coast. The ship, sailing between the Vizhinjam and Kochi ports, had 24 crew members, rescued well in time. But the real trouble lay beneath the waves: several containers of hazardous cargo, now submerged or bobbing ashore in Thiruvananthapuram, Kollam and Alappuzha. Salvage crews are still racing to prevent the ship's fuel tanks from leaking oil, but the greater menace may be the plastic nurdles—tiny, insidious pellets used in

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